

Cat Overstimulation Management: A Practical Guide for Exhausted Cat Owners — Action Checklist

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SCHEDULE VETERINARY ASSESSMENT

- ☐ **Schedule a vet appointment this week for sudden behavior changes — sudden aggression, inappropriate elimination, nighttime vocalization, and destructiveness have a medical root cause in the majority of documented cases and need diagnosis before behavioral training begins.:** Schedule a vet appointment this week for sudden behavior changes — sudden aggression, inappropriate elimination, nighttime vocalization, and destructiveness have a medical root cause in the majority of documented cases and need diagnosis before behavioral training begins.
- ☐ **Request a urinalysis to check for UTI, crystals, and bladder cells — urinary issues cause cats to avoid the litter box because they associate it with pain, and this test identifies the most common medical cause of inappropriate urination.:** Request a urinalysis to check for UTI, crystals, and bladder cells — urinary issues cause cats to avoid the litter box because they associate it with pain, and this test identifies the most common medical cause of inappropriate urination.
- ☐ **Request a senior blood panel checking kidney function, thyroid levels, and blood sugar — these two tests catch the majority of medical causes for behavioral change and typically cost between \$150–\$350 depending on your area.:** Request a senior blood panel checking kidney function, thyroid levels, and blood sugar — these two tests catch the majority of medical causes for behavioral change and typically cost between \$150–\$350 depending on your area.
- ☐ **Write down all recent behavior changes before your vet visit — list aggression, nighttime vocalization, litter box issues, and destructiveness with when each started so your vet has complete information for diagnosis.:** Write down all recent behavior changes before your vet visit — list aggression, nighttime vocalization, litter box issues, and destructiveness with when each started so your vet has complete information for diagnosis.

COMPLETE HUNT-CATCH-KILL-EAT PLAY

- ❑ **Schedule two 10-minute wand toy play sessions per day — one in the morning before work and one in the evening after dinner — because cats who complete the hunt cycle 2–3 times daily are calmer and less destructive.:** Schedule two 10-minute wand toy play sessions per day — one in the morning before work and one in the evening after dinner — because cats who complete the hunt cycle 2–3 times daily are calmer and less destructive.
- ❑ **Move wand toys erratically with short dashes, sudden stops, and direction changes — mimicking real prey movement satisfies your cat's stalking instinct before you let them catch the toy.:** Move wand toys erratically with short dashes, sudden stops, and direction changes — mimicking real prey movement satisfies your cat's stalking instinct before you let them catch the toy.
- ❑ **Let your cat physically catch and "kill" the toy at the end of each session — a cat who stalks and chases but never catches becomes more frustrated, not less, so always end with the capture moment.:** Let your cat physically catch and "kill" the toy at the end of each session — a cat who stalks and chases but never catches becomes more frustrated, not less, so always end with the capture moment.
- ❑ **Feed 3–5 treats immediately after each play session to complete the Hunt-Catch-Kill-Eat cycle — this mirrors the natural post-hunt meal and creates behavioral satisfaction that bowl feeding cannot provide.:** Feed 3–5 treats immediately after each play session to complete the Hunt-Catch-Kill-Eat cycle — this mirrors the natural post-hunt meal and creates behavioral satisfaction that bowl feeding cannot provide.

SET UP FOOD ENRICHMENT STATIONS

- ❑ **Replace bowl feeding entirely with food puzzles to turn mealtime into a hunt — puzzles provide mental stimulation equivalent to 30–60 minutes of interactive play per day and reduce boredom-based destruction.:** Replace bowl feeding entirely with food puzzles to turn mealtime into a hunt — puzzles provide mental stimulation equivalent to 30–60 minutes of interactive play per day and reduce boredom-based destruction.
- ❑ **Make a toilet paper roll puzzle by rolling both ends closed, poking small holes in it, and filling it with kibble — cats spend 5–10 minutes working it open and this costs nothing to create.:** Make a toilet paper roll puzzle by rolling both ends closed, poking small holes in it, and filling it with kibble — cats spend 5–10 minutes working it open and this costs nothing to create.

- ☐ **Place kibble in a muffin tin's wells and cover each well with a tennis ball — your cat must nose out each ball to access food, turning breakfast into a challenging hunt activity.:** Place kibble in a muffin tin's wells and cover each well with a tennis ball — your cat must nose out each ball to access food, turning breakfast into a challenging hunt activity.
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- ☐ **Fill a loosely closed Amazon box with kibble and tear several holes in the sides — scatter the kibble throughout the box so your cat works to retrieve pieces, replicating natural hunting conditions.:** Fill a loosely closed Amazon box with kibble and tear several holes in the sides — scatter the kibble throughout the box so your cat works to retrieve pieces, replicating natural hunting conditions.
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